

The Unkindest Cut of All

The Fight To Halt Routine Infant Circumcisions

by David O'Connor

Marilyn Milos witnessed her first infant circumcision as a nursing student in 1979 — and the horror of that experience remains with her still.

In an account of the surgery that she wrote nearly ten years later, Milos describes entering a nursery to find a newborn strapped spread-eagle to a plastic board, whimpering as he struggled against his restraints. Milos remembers comforting the baby, who stopped crying momentarily.

"The silence was soon broken by a piercing scream — the baby's reaction to having his foreskin pinched and crushed as the doctor attached the clamp to his penis," Milos writes. "The shriek intensified when the doctor inserted an instrument between the foreskin and the glans [head of the penis], tearing the two structures apart."

"The baby started shaking his head back and forth — the only part of his body free to move — as the doctor used another clamp to crush the foreskin lengthwise, which he then cut," Milos continues. "The baby began to gasp and choke, breathless from his shrill, continuous screams."

"How could anyone say circumcision is painless when the suffering is so obvious?" Milos asks. "My bottom lip

began to quiver, tears filled my eyes and spilled over. I found my own sobs difficult to contain."

In the years since that experience, Milos, now a registered nurse, has joined a national grass-roots movement to end routine circumcision of infants in the United States.

A colleague in that fight is Tim Hammond of the National Organization to Halt the Abuse and Routine Mutilation of Males (NO HARMM). Based in San Francisco, NO HARMM counts 1,200 people on its national mailing list, despite mores that make foreskin a taboo topic for discussion, Hammond says.

"Men are afraid to speak up because they don't want to be seen as perverted," says Hammond. "Anytime a man starts talking about his penis, homophobia creeps in. And what man wants to admit that his dick isn't everything that nature intended."

NO HARMM aims to educate people about benefits of foreskin, document hazards of circumcision, and lobby medical associations to adopt policies against routine infant circumcision. The organization is one of at least a dozen similar groups across the country.

"We have become such a nation of circumcised men that nobody stops to think about foreskin or what its benefits might be," Hammond

says. "We seem to think it comes into the world with a sign that says cut at dotted line."

Defended as cure-all

Many doctors defend infant circumcision as a necessary surgery to prevent several physical ailments, chiefly urinary tract infection, penile cancer, sexually transmitted disease, and cervical cancer in female sex partners.

The American Medical Association (AMA) has no formal policy regarding infant male circumcision, although it officially opposes female circumcision, according to an AMA spokesperson.

The California Medical Association considers male newborn circumcision a "valid public health measure" according to spokesperson Paul Moreno.

But since 1971, the American Academy of Pediatrics (AAP) has maintained there is "no absolute medical indication for routine circumcision of the newborn." Both the American College of Obstetricians and Gynecologists and the American Urological Association support that position.

The AAP says that circumcision has "potential medical benefits and advantages as well as inherent disadvantages and risks."

Studies suggesting urinary

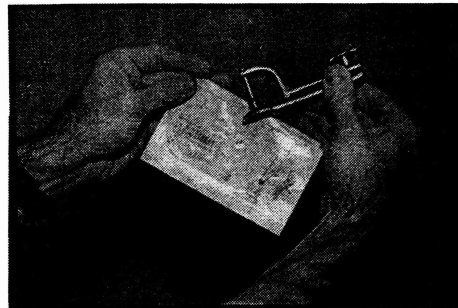
tract infections are more prevalent among uncircumcised men are methodologically flawed, the AAP says. "In the absence of well-designed prospective studies, conclusions regarding the relationship of urinary tract infection to circumcision are tentative," according to the AAP.

Also inconclusive is evidence linking circumcision to reduced incidence of sexually transmitted disease or increased incidence of cervical cancer in sex partners, the AAP says.

George Denniston, a doctor specializing in preventive medicine and gynecology, wrote in a 1989 article in *The Truth Seeker*, "There is general agreement that the hygiene of men who develop cancer of the penis has been poor. ... Cancer of the penis is very rare — one case in 100,000 — usually in older men. Even if circumcision could prevent it, 100,000 foreskin amputations would be necessary to prevent one cancer of the penis."

The AAP agrees that penile cancer is a rare condition occurring in elderly men and linked to poor hygiene.

"What the Academy of Pediatrics did not say is that the potential benefits of leaving men intact outweigh the known risks," says Milos. "They said parents should come to a decision, but gave clear sailing for pro-circumcision advocates to keep conjuring up excuses and make this country a safe place for the circumciser and an unsafe place for baby boys to be born into."



Two devices used in circumcising infants — the Plastibell and the Gomco Clamp. Both are used as guides and restraints for cutting off the foreskin.

(Photo: Rick Gerhartner)

Milos is founder of the National Organization of Circumcision Information Resource Centers (NOCIRC) located in San Anselmo. In 1985, she was fired from her job as a nurse at Marin General Hospital because she showed parents a video of infant circumcisions. Milos was told she was disturbing parents.

"That's the right response, they should all be upset," Milos says. "Every parent has a right and obligation to know what's done to their baby behind closed doors. There's a scream that hits you on a primal level. The sound of that scream is like a scream you don't hear in any other time; that's a baby screaming for help."

In 1988, the California Nurses Association presented Milos with its highest honor, the Maureen Ricke Award, for her work "to raise consciousness about America's most unnecessary surgery."

It's not easy to raise that consciousness, Milos says, because the rationalizations for circumcision are steeped in a long history of religious and cultural myths.

Irrational justifications

"Circumcision is not a medical issue," says Milos. "For proof of that we only need to look at the 85 percent of the world's male population that is not circumcised without the dire consequences our medical community tells us will happen if we leave our sons intact. But then, circumcision is a quarter-billion dollar industry in the United States."

In her book, *Circumcision: What Every Parent Should Know*, Ann Briggs discusses how circumcision is thought to have originated in primitive tribal societies as "a way of humiliating and/or outwardly marking those captured into slavery. ...